OTT

WE ARE LIKE THIS ONLY

Amazon Prime's new comedy show, ***The Pradeeps of Pittsburgh***, follows the adventures of an Indian family adapting to a new life in the US

"In India when you tell a story you always add a little masala," says Sudha Pradeep, a Gujarati surgeon and mother of three, in the upcoming Amazon Prime show *The Pradeeps of Pittsburgh*. "This is America, here we like our stories plain," replies a cop questioning the eponymous family for an incident in which they are suspects. The Vijal Patel–created show follows the adventures of the family as they try to adapt to a whole new world. Partly inspired by Patel's family's experience moving to the US, the show stars British-Indian actor Naveen Andrews (best known for *Lost*) as Mahesh, the overtly optimistic patriarch who looks to excel in the "land of opportunity". For Andrews, the series offered him the rare opportunity to do a sitcom and also essay a character whose attitude amidst adversity is "something to aspire to".

Says Andrews, "Where my parents came from [Kerala] and their experience moving from India to England was very different. It was a different time and what they were facing was a completely different ballgame in terms of hostility. What attracted me to Mahesh was that he has no bitterness or rage. There is something about his gentleness and genuine goodwill that astonishes me."

The Pradeeps... arrives at a time when US shows like *Master of None* and *Never Have I Ever* have touched upon the life of Indian immigrants, and the presence of South Asian characters in mainstream shows isn't rare (*The Mindy Project*, *Quantico*, etc). The US entertainment industry, notes Patel, is now more open to having stories around the experiences of minorities. "With the proliferation of content, they are looking for more representation not just out of diversity for diversity's sake, but they realise there are more interesting stories to be told from a lens which we haven't seen before," he adds. "I have always longed to tell this personal story and I am glad that the global market has caught up to let us tell these interesting stories."

EVEN THOUGH IT IS AUTOBIOGRAPHICAL, SHOW CREATOR VIJAL PATEL SAYS IT IS ONLY 20 PER CENT REALITY, "ALL THE FEELINGS ARE 100 PER CENT"

Compared to other immigrant stories already seen, Patel wanted to look at a family that isn't troubled by the move. For starters, the Pradeep kids are well-versed with American pop culture, and a host of hard issues like racism, the struggle to fit in and bullying are broached with a humorous lens. "They have a dream and they come and immediately hit the ground running," says Patel. "Conflict arises around assimilation but their problems are family problems."

Even as *The Pradeeps...* is autobiographical, Patel admits that the show is only 20 per cent reality, "all the feelings are 100 per cent". Patel roped in three Indian-American writers to bring more authentic perspectives. Working on popular TV shows, particularly *Black-ish*, he says, taught him to "learn the art of telling a broader story" by being open to "other ideas" and "veer away from his exact experience". *The Pradeeps...* is a "letter back home", he says. "We all know someone who has emigrated to the US. My mom and dad's brothers and sisters in India will watch the show and they'd be like, this is what happened to Mukund and Sarla [his parents]." And hopefully they'll laugh. ■

–Suhani Singh



DIASPORA DREAMS
The show stars British-Indian actor Naveen Andrews (centre) as Mahesh, the overtly optimistic patriarch